

5. The Ultimate Failure of China's Feudalization

Since China's feudalization (封建化) had reached such an extent, why did it not continue to deepen as it did in Europe, but instead shortly pivoted onto the path of re-bureaucratization (再官僚化), eventually forming the Sui and Tang empires?

Looking at the surface-level situation, it was because the rulers—despite undergoing a certain degree of feudalization—never abandoned the pursuit of becoming true despotic monarchs. If we compare the situations in Guandong (关东) and Guanxi (关西), it is not difficult to discover that the Eastern Wei-Northern Qi in Guandong was in a more advantageous position for feudalization than the Western Wei-Northern Zhou in Guanxi. This was not only because Guandong possessed economic and demographic superiority and housed the vast majority of the north's feudalized aristocratic great clans (大士族), but also because Gao Huan evidently inherited far more of the military forces from the Six Garrisons than Yuwen Tai did, which meant the former had an even more intense need for feudalization.

Therefore, the Western Wei-Northern Zhou regime was swiftly able to establish a new bureaucratic politics under the banner of restoring antiquity (as discussed in *A Study on the Nine-Rank System of Personnel Selection* / 《九品官人法研究》), and ultimately restored the absolute authority of the monarch on this foundation.

In Guandong, however, the political inclinations of the brothers Gao Cheng (高澄) and Gao Yang (高洋) formed a dramatic contrast with Hōjō Yasutoki (北条泰时). While playing the identical role of surveilling the nominal supreme ruler on behalf of the feudal shogunate, Hōjō Yasutoki was well aware that he was the spokesperson for the Shogunate, defending the interests of the Shogunate and the samurai (武士). But the Gao brothers did not stand on the side of Jinyang; instead, they strengthened the court's authority in Ye (邺城) and intended to ultimately replace "China's Emperor" (equivalent to the Japanese Tennō)—namely, Emperor Xiaojing, Yuan Shanjian—to position themselves at the absolute apex of bureaucratic rule.

This also explains the most dramatic historical event at the end of the Northern and Southern Dynasties: Hou Jing's (侯景) two rebellions in Eastern Wei and Southern Liang. There is reason to believe that Hou Jing, as the great lord holding autocratic control over Henan and the number one vassal of the Gao Shogunate, could not possibly have been oblivious to what was happening in Jinyang and Ye. He naturally deduced, based on Gao Cheng's past behavior, that Gao would inevitably not tolerate a powerful feudal lord (封建领主) like himself, making it imperative to preemptively launch a rebellion.

In reality, for Hou Jing to have acquired such colossal power, he certainly could not have been a fool, and historical records do not view him as a fool either. For a feudal lord, there is no logical reason to rebel simply because his liege lord underwent a normal generational succession. Even in the loosely structured Holy Roman Empire, the princes would not, in the vast majority of cases, rebel simply because a new emperor was crowned. As long as the relationship of feudal obligations remained unchanged and the guarantee of his original fiefdom (honryō ando / 本领安堵) was not violated, what profit motive would a vassal have to undertake such highly risky behavior?

Meanwhile, since Gao Huan—as the dominator of this brief period of dual polity (二元政治)—tacitly approved of Gao Cheng's actions in Ye, it is evident that he himself was not inclined to maintain the dual rule of the Shogunate and the Court. Naturally, he knew that further bureaucratization after Gao Cheng took power would shake the trust of the subordinate lords. Thus, he easily "predicted Hou Jing's prediction" (预判了侯景的预判).

In this way, we provide a rational explanation for Hou Jing's initial rebellion based on standpoint and profit motive, rather than resorting to morality and personal character.

Returning to the main topic, the move by Gao Huan's descendants to decide to become the emperors of China rather than the supreme lord of their vassals was, of course, a success. Gao Yang accepted the abdication from Yuan Shanjian and established the Northern Qi (北齐) regime.

However, such success was so incomplete, because the feudal shogunate in Jinyang could not possibly vanish overnight, and the feudalized (封建化) Xianbei warriors remained the military backbone of the court. This being the case, the contradiction between Ye and Jinyang inevitably led to turbulence in the court. The third emperor of Northern Qi, Emperor Xiaozhao, Gao Yan (孝昭帝高演), launched a coup d'état relying on supporters from Jinyang. He ascended the throne and ruled there, and only after his death was his coffin transported to Ye for burial.

Another extremely important political figure, Gao Huan's wife Lou Zhaojun (娄昭君), similarly and evidently favored Jinyang while distancing herself from Ye. When Gao Yang was preparing to force Emperor Xiaojing to abdicate, Lou Zhaojun, as a mother, expressed resolute opposition, so much so that Gao Yang had to postpone it. Ten years later, Lou Zhaojun supported her son Gao Yan in deposing her grandson Gao Yin (Book of Northern Qi, Biographies 1 / 《北齐书列传第一》).

Under this situation, suspicion, doubt, and conspiracy ran rampant in the Northern Qi court, making its political chaos even worse than that of Northern Zhou. Unlike the dictatorial power of Yuwen Hu (宇文护) in Northern Zhou, which basically maintained the rule of the Yuwen clan, the internal chaos in Northern Qi plunged the state into severe internal friction. Numerous illustrious ministers and renowned generals died unjustly, and its national power was drastically diminished.

The result of such a developing situation was that, although Northern Qi initially held an obvious advantage over Northern Zhou in national strength, it was ultimately Northern Zhou that swallowed and destroyed Northern Qi, effectively ending the Gao family's rule in Guandong. Regardless of the Gao family's fate, the destruction of the original feudalization (封建化) process in Northern China is an obvious fact. And just like that, the most critical historical window of opportunity for the Chinese people was lost.

When the Sui and Tang rulers re-embraced bureaucratic politics, they absolutely did not simply want to return to the zenith of the Han dynasty, nor could they possibly do so.

After six centuries of economic development and social transformation, the era characterized primarily by strong personal dependency (人身依附), where the direct enslavement of the labor force served as the primary mode of exploitation, had long faded. Although the institution of slavery still existed in various forms within society, it was no longer the primary characteristic of society.

In reality, no matter how politics fluctuated at the middle and upper echelons, in the vast rural areas of the empire, the exploitation method based on rent and taxes ultimately became mainstream due to its higher efficiency. The feudal landlord class (封建地主阶级) emerged and dominated the social production of the empire. Economic feudalization had already occurred, and it became a major challenge to the restoration-bureaucratic empire (复辟官僚帝国).

中文原文：

5, 中国封建化的最终失败

既然中国的封建化已经到达了这样一种地步，那它为什么没有像欧洲那样继续深入下去，而是在不久就转入了再官僚化的道路，进而形成了隋唐帝国呢？从表面的情况上看，那就是有一定封建化的统治者从来没有放弃成为一个真正的专制君主。如果比较关东和关西的情况，那么不难发现关东的东魏—北齐具有比关西的西魏—北周处于更有利于封建化的局面，这不仅是因为关东具有经济人口上的优势，生活着绝大多数北方封建化的大士族，而且高欢和宇文泰两人对于六镇兵马的继承情况也明显是前者多于后者，这意味着前者有更加强烈的封建化的需求。所以西魏—北周政权很快就能打着复古的旗号建立新的官僚政治（《九品官人法研究》），并最终在其基础上恢复君主的绝对权威。

而在关东，高澄高洋两兄弟的政治倾向则与北条泰时形成了戏剧性的对比，同样扮演一个代表封建幕府监视名义最高统治者的角色，北条泰时很清楚自己是幕府的代言人，维护的是幕府和武士们的利益。但是高氏兄弟没有站在晋阳一边，反而在邺城加强朝廷的权威，并且意图最终取代中国的天皇，也就是孝静帝元善见，使自己立于官僚统治的顶点。由此也可以解释南北朝末期最戏剧性的历史事件，也就是侯景在东魏和南梁的两次叛乱。有理由认为，侯景作为专制河南的大领主，高氏幕府下第一号的封臣，不可能对于晋阳和邺城发生的事情一无所知，他当然会判断根据高澄以往的表现，必然不会容忍自己这样强大的封建领主，所以必须要先发制人进行叛乱。实际上，侯景能够取得如此庞大的权力，当然不可能是一个傻瓜，历史记录也不认可他是个傻瓜。作为一个封建领主而言，没有道理仅仅是自己的封君进行了正常代际之间的更替就非要造反不可，即使是松散的神圣罗马帝国，在绝大多数情况下诸侯们也不会在换一个皇帝的时候叛乱。只要封建义务关系不改变，自己的本领安堵不受侵犯，诸侯哪里有利益动机做出如此高风险的行为？而高欢作为这段短暂二元政治的主导者，既然默许了高澄在邺城的所作所为，可见他本人也并不是倾向于维持幕府和朝廷的二元统治，自然就知道高澄执政后进一步官僚化会动摇属下领主的信任，于是轻易地预判了侯景的叛乱。这样一来，我们就对侯景最初的叛乱在立场和利益动机上给出了一个合理的解释，而不是诉诸道德和个人性格。

回到正题，高欢的子孙决定当中国的皇帝而不是封臣们的最高领主的举措当然取得了成功，高洋从元善见那里接受了禅让，建立了北齐政权。可这样的成功却又那么不彻底，因为晋阳的封建幕府不可能在一日之间销声匿迹，封建化的鲜卑武士仍然是朝廷的军事支柱。既然如此，邺城和晋阳之间的矛盾就势必导致朝局的动荡，北齐的第三个皇帝孝昭帝高演便凭借晋阳方面的支持者发动了政变，在那里登基并且统治，直到去世之后才将棺椁运往邺城安葬。另一个极为重要的政治人物，高欢的夫人娄昭君同样明显亲近晋阳而疏远邺城，在高洋准备强迫孝静帝禅让之时，作为母亲的娄昭君表示了坚决的反对，以至于高洋不得不将其推后。十年之后，娄昭君又支持自己的儿子高演废掉了自己的孙子高殷（《北齐书列传第一》）。在这种局面下，猜忌、怀疑和阴谋在北齐的宫廷中大行其道，政治混乱更甚于北周，与北周宇文护的专权基本维持了宇文氏的统治不同，北齐内部的混乱使得国家陷入剧烈内耗，名臣名将冤死者众，实力大为衰减。如此形势发展的结果是，尽管北齐最初在国力上对于北周占据明显的优势，但是最终是北周吞灭了北齐，高氏在关东的统治被终结了。而无论高氏的结局如何，中国北方原有的封建化进程遭到破坏是显而易见的事实，就这样，对中国人而言最重要的一个历史窗口期便如此失去了。

当隋唐统治者重新拥抱官僚政治的时候，他们绝不是简简单单地要回到汉代的鼎盛局面，也不可能这样做了。经过六个世纪的经济发展和社会变动，以强人身依附为主要特征，直接奴役劳动力主要剥削方式的时代已经远去，奴隶制度虽然仍以各种形式存在于社会之中，但已经不再是社会的主要特征。实际上，无论中高层的政治如何变动，在帝国的广大农村，以租税为剥削方式终究还是因其更具效率成为主流，封建地主阶级兴起并且主导了帝国的社会生产，经济上的封建化已经发生了，并且成为复辟官僚帝国的重要挑战。